

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 195

Culture (OWC): [Amhara \(MP05\)](#)

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Section Title(S)

3.8.1.6 Servants and economic considerations • 3.8.2 Age stratification

Long interpersonal relations usually improve the position of the servant with respect to master, and it is not in the servant's interest to change jobs, or to go to another area where he is unknown. A landless gebbar may try to attach himself to a well-to-do household as "retainer" (zega) without wages, doing a servant's work in the hope of occasional, seasonal gifts, a share of the produce, or in town, a share in trade. A servant or retainer who is Amhara at'intam and Orthodox Christian becomes like a member of the extended family. The proverb says:

■ "When (women) grind (grain) together, there is no mistress".

357
Domestic Service

539
Literary Texts

592
Household

Economic wealth enables each of these social classes to achieve some upward social mobility within limits. But there are not many opportunities to accumulate much wealth. Traders can raise their status in towns, despite doubtful ancestry. The same is true of tailors, a very recent occupation in town, where foot-operated Singer sewing machines have enabled men to set up shops along the main street leading to the market, or at the market itself, manufacturing khaki shorts and jackets. But this is still considered shameful manual labor by the Amhara, so that he will pursue it only in another province where it does not shame his kinfolk.

556
Accumulation Of
Wealth

A rich man, whose low ancestry may be whispered behind his back, is nevertheless usually treated with honor by Amhara commoners. The proverb says:

■ "He who falls in a shallow place hurt will not come to him"

(i.e. a rich man, even if he falls drunk in a gutter, will not be molested by ruffians, who will instead take him to his house, expecting a reward).

539
Literary Texts

556
Accumulation Of
Wealth

"The water of (the rainy month) n[unknown]hase is good, yet no one will drink it; the word of the poor man may be fruitful, but no one will listen to him"

(i.e. he is not appreciated, no matter how wise).

3.8.2 Age stratification

Age stratification among the Amhara ranks in emphasis between class stratification and sex stratification.

561
Age Stratification

The social relation of the old toward the young is often likened by the Amhara to that of master to servant. Indeed, a young man between puberty and marriage is addressed as *ashker* (lit. servant). A young girl of the same age is addressed and even referred to as l[unknown]jag[unknown]r[unknown]d (lit. servant maid, handmaiden).

561
Age Stratification

The functions of the young literally follow these terms. Even boys attending church school do pasturing of  196 the flock before and after their lessons, and school is recessed during plowing and harvesting seasons. Elder brothers may and do discipline their juniors, despite the superficial "joking relationship" between siblings of the same sex. As *ashker*, the young bachelor is constantly at the beck and call of his father and other elders of the extended family. At feasts, the father may show affectionate approval by feeding his son hand-to-mouth, the "gur[unknown]sa", also given to servants and other social inferiors.

561
Age Stratification

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